weapons which the working people have put into their hands in such a way as to protect the victory of socialism.'5

As a scan through the East German newspaper archives reveals, Honecker had become a minor celebrity by this point. Few military parades, tattoos, full-dress inspections or conferences were complete without his valued contribution. Once, on a visit to troops, he interrupted a display of physical exercises, stripped to the waist, and performed a difficult shoulder balance on the parallel bars.

After the Fifth SED Congress, Honecker eased the pressure on professors and intellectuals, cooling his drive to suppress liberal tendencies and freer thinking in universities. The reason for this reversal was the flight of intellectuals to the West. As the human exodus continued, a solution was taking shape in Ulbricht's head. At his instigation, Khrushchev tried to drive the Western powers out of Berlin by serving notice on France, Britain and the United States on 10 November 1958, to get out of the 'capital of the German Democratic Republic' within six months. If they refused, he promised to sign a peace treaty with the GDR, which (he contended) would terminate the legal justification for the Allied deployment in the city.6

However, the threat wasn't enough for the Americans, British or French to rise, and their unity and resolve remained unbroken. For the Allies, there was no doubt that the departure of the 10,000-strong Western defence force from Berlin would lead to the absorption of the 2.2 million West Berliners into the GDR. Thus, in a meeting of the North Atlantic Council, the Allies stated they were determined to maintain their position and rights in Berlin, including the right of free access. 'We are solemnly committed to hold West Berlin, if need be, by military force,' US Secretary of State Dulles crowed.7

Meanwhile, to the surprise of no one, Ulbricht's tone kept getting colder. In a New Year's message, he described West Berlin as a 'cancerous growth' that must be operated on during 1959. Even the decrepit president, Wilhelm Pieck, added to the drama when wheeled out to say NATO attempts to save West Berlin would fail. Unable to resist the chance to simultaneously boost his profile and yank the FRG's chain, Honecker assisted Defence Minister Willi Stoph and Interior Minister Karl Maron in issuing 'Orders of The